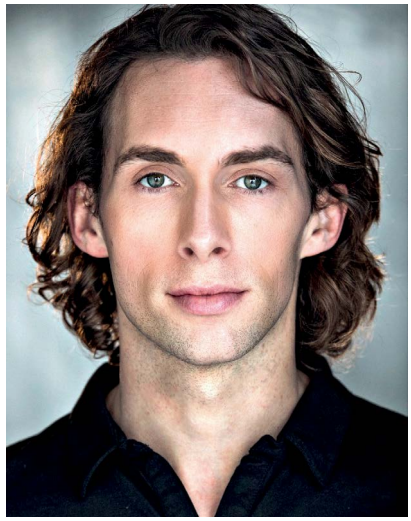


up fully every night," she adds.

Apart from each member of the huge cast and crew who do just that, one of the most memorable parts of the production for anyone who has watched *Cats* is the junkyard set. What can we expect to see at the NMACC's Grand Theatre? "The set is still gloriously oversized and immersive—audiences should feel as though they've shrunk to the size of a cat the moment they enter the theatre. Technically, there are always refinements in materials, automation and staging to make the production more efficient and sustainable for modern touring, but visually it retains the rich, textured world audiences know and love. It's still the most glamorous rubbish heap in theatre!" says Krzan.

Fans of *Cats* have always been enamoured by 'Memory', the show's signature number sung by Grizabella. How does Abrahams interpret the body language of a once-glamorous, now shunned and ageing cat, who finally gets her moment in the spotlight? "It's really all in the detail," she says. "You see someone who's learned to protect herself over time, so there's a certain guardedness in how she moves; like she's not used to taking up space anymore. Yet traces of Grizabella's former self remain visible. "Every now and then, you get these small glimpses of who she used to be," says Abrahams. "A bit of lift, a bit of presence, something that hints at her past." And as 'Memory' unfolds, those "layers slowly start to come off". "It becomes less about performance and more about truth," she explains. "Very raw, very human... and quite moving in a quiet way." ■

—Priya Pathiyan

"THEATRE IS ALWAYS IN CONVERSATION WITH THE WORLD AROUND IT. AND THAT ONGOING EVOLUTION IS PART OF WHY *CATS* STILL HAS NINE LIVES," SAYS RESIDENT DIRECTOR MATT KRZAN

really demanding, but in a very rewarding way. There's a deep emotional history in this character, you feel it in everything she does, even the silence between moments. She carries a lot, and that weight is always present on stage." What Abrahams finds most compelling is the character's quiet resilience. "She doesn't fall apart easily; even in her most vulnerable moments, there's still something solid underneath. That complexity is what makes her such a privilege to play, but it also means you have to really show

Cats will be performed live at the NMACC, Mumbai, from ***Jun. 17-28***

impending invasion by Emperor Akbar.

It may sound like a heavy historical drama, but Rawal infuses the narrative with an unexpected, sharp wit that makes the fictional 16th-century kingdom of Banasvan feel remarkably immediate. Written during the writer and actor's master's studies at New York University Tisch School of the Arts, *The Queen* was his first play to hit the stage, debuting at the historic Theater for the New City in June 2016. It was an instant hit, earning audience and critical acclaim, and bagging the New York Innovative Theatre Award for Best Original Script in 2017.

THE PLAY **BAGGED THE NEW YORK INNOVATIVE THEATRE AWARD** IN 2017 FOLLOWING ITS DEBUT AT THE THEATER FOR THE NEW CITY

When Rawal decided to bring the play to India, he knew he wanted to introduce a lot of changes to the script. "I have changed as a writer in the last decade," he reflects. "I wanted to sharpen a few things and see how it plays out to an Indian audience." To test the waters, the team did a staged reading at the Prithvi Festival Fringe in 2024 and followed it up with a premiere at Prithvi Festival in 2025, with Daniel Owen Dsouza directing the play.

The casting of Sarup as Queen Durga, according to Rawal, has taken the play up a few notches. "As an actor, she has moved me the most and the one that I enjoy seeing the most on a Bombay stage," he says. "The power and presence she carries on stage, while having fun with her character, have been enlightening for me to watch." The play has been performed in Bengaluru, Puducherry and Ahmedabad, and Rawal hopes to bring it to Delhi, Goa and Chandigarh later this year. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The Queen *will be staged at Mumbai's Prithvi Theatre from* ***Jun. 25-26***